

NANDINI PILLAI

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SUMMARY

UX & Product Designer who takes products end-to-end, from ambiguous brief to shipped release. Most recently the sole designer on **LUCA**, an AI careers platform now live in production with **16,000+ student users**, where I owned the work from research to final UI. I work across research, IA, interaction design, and design systems — turning user needs and real-world constraints into products that ship.

EDUCATION

Lancaster University MA Design Management	United Kingdom 2024 - 2025
Symbiosis International University Bachelor of Design (B. Des) – Product/Industrial Design	India 2019 - 2023

EXPERIENCE

ISS Innovation Hub, Lancaster University UX Designer	United Kingdom May'25 - Dec'25
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- Sole designer on **LUCA, an AI careers platform live in production** — owned it end-to-end from problem definition through every screen of the v1 release: **19 features across 6 functional areas**, built within GDPR, no-AI-training, and bias-audit constraints.
- **Built and governed the product's design system** — holding type, colour, spacing, and components consistent across **80+ screens** of a live app used by **16,000+ students** — and restructured the information architecture to cut a core daily flow by **3 steps**.
- Defined **where the AI assists the user and where it stays out** — the central design risk — translating institutional constraints into product requirements and rebuilding a confusing IA after testing exposed it as the real failure point.
- Ran research with **40+ participants** across **5+ co-design workshops**, turning findings into **3 roadmap-level improvements** delivered with engineers and PMs in agile sprints.

Imagination Lab, Lancaster University Freelance Design Consultant (client: Yifei Wang)	United Kingdom Jan'25 - Apr'25
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- Set **product positioning and go-to-market strategy** for a UK early-stage startup, integrating UX, service blueprinting, and brand.
- Led **user and competitor research** with **15+ participants** to shape MVP feature prioritisation.
- Delivered a strategy and roadmap **adopted by the client**, shaping its positioning, investor narrative, and early MVP plan.

Smartivity Labs Pvt. Ltd. Product Designer	India Oct'23 - Jul'24
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- Owned **end-to-end product design** for an interactive STEM learning product, validated through **5+ usability tests** that improved engagement and retention.
- Mapped **user journeys and interaction flows** on behavioural principles, partnering with engineering to **cut unit cost 15%** without compromising the experience.
- Contributed UX thinking across the broader product range, translating insights from testing into design decisions that held up through manufacture.

Imagimake Play Solutions Ltd. Design Intern	India Dec'22 - May'23
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- Contributed **UX and concept design across 4+ product ranges**, from early concepts through prototype iterations.
- Designed **instructional systems** that **cut support queries ~20%** and ran **observational user testing** to refine usability.

SKILLS

Product & Strategy: End-to-End Product Design, Product Strategy, Design Systems, AI Product Design, Service Design

Craft & Research: Interaction Design, UI & Visual Design, Prototyping, User Research, Usability Testing, Heuristic Evaluation, Information Architecture, Accessibility

Ways of Working: Cross-functional Collaboration, Design Facilitation, Stakeholder Management, Agile Delivery

Tools: Figma, Adobe XD, Creative Suite, Miro, FigJam